

Takaa Awori, *Leadership in Africa Redefined*

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Chapter Twelve

SHARE LEADERSHIP

As an older person, you might one-time dance to
the beat or rhythm of a young person.

—Runyakitara proverb [20]

ONE DAY IN THE NOT-too-distant past, I got lost driving to a hotel I had never been to before. I had followed Google Maps to a dead end. At this point, I thought enough of technology. It's time to rely on the human factor. I asked a young man who was leaving his house for directions. He looked at me and said in his beautiful Ghanaian English, "Ooh, you have lost your way." He was about to start giving me directions, thought better of it, and said, "Follow me." So, he jumped on his bicycle and led me on a five-minute drive to the venue.

As I followed this gracious young man to my destination, I thought about leadership. Sometimes, even when you are sure about where you want to go as a leader, there will be moments when others have more expertise, and you have to trust them to lead. You will still ultimately be responsible, but you are willing to let others step up and lead. This is what this chapter is about. It's about shared leadership, which can be described as the distribution of power and influence in an organisation to achieve shared goals irrespective of hierarchy.

Change the Mindset and Attitude about Leadership

The model of patriarchal leadership where the person at the top, usually an older man, makes all the decisions even when he has no clue what he is doing is outdated. This leadership style is no longer relevant to what Africa needs to unlock its potential.

This chapter is about the model of leadership in which everyone is encouraged to grow as leaders, whether they have a title or not. While those with titles have formal authority, everyone can influence others to achieve a shared goal. It starts with a certain mindset. The definition and understanding of leadership must evolve from the idea that it only resides in one person to the possibility of it residing in many people. It must change from leadership solely derived from a position to leadership derived from the willingness to step forward and influence others to achieve a shared goal.

Angela, the women's rights activist I talked about in Chapter Two, shared an incident during the Sisters' Keepers Campaign that vividly captures this idea of shared leadership. One day the women decided to march to Parliament early in the morning. They didn't have mobile phones in those days, so they called each other up the night before on landlines with news of the decision to go to Parliament the following morning. By 7:30 am, they were in parliament house, but they found an army band and an Air Force

band happily practising when they got there. The women quickly realised that the band had been summoned to be there because the authorities had found out the women were coming.

Not intimidated by the band, the women went ahead to protest, demanding that they see the parliamentarians. Then, the leadership of Parliament came out, looking very nervous, and asked, "Who is the leader of this gathering?" All of a sudden, all the women raised their hands, stating, "We are all the leaders of this gathering." Clearly, all of these women saw themselves as leaders. This is the power of shared leadership

Understandably, this mindset is not easy to change. Those who have worked hard over many years to gain leadership positions might be hesitant to give up their power and privilege. Yet, being instrumental in bringing about change, they still need to think in terms of we, not me.

Madame Bineta Diop is an example of a leader who thinks in terms of shared, not individual leadership. She is the Special Envoy of the Chairperson of the African Union Commission on Women, Peace and Security and the founder and President of Femmes Africa Solidarité (FAS), an international NGO based in Geneva with operations office in Dakar, Senegal. Madame Diop was instrumental in getting the African Union to adopt the Gender Parity Principle in 2002, the Solemn Declaration on Gender Equality in Africa in 2004, and the Protocol to the African Charter on Human and People's Rights on the Rights of Women in Africa in 2003.

Ultimately, Madam Diop has had a formidable influence on women's rights and women, and peace and security on this continent. When I spoke to Madam Diop about all the positive changes she contributed to this continent, she was reluctant to talk about herself. Instead, she talked about "us" and "we." For Madame Diop, the type of leadership she had to exercise to achieve an impact was consensus-building and collective leadership.

For example, Madame Diop has advocated for the inclusion of women in peace-building. Even though women are more affected by conflict, they are excluded from decision-making spaces of conflict resolution. In South Sudan, for example, the inclusion of women in peace processes has been short of the 35% commitment made by the government. Madame Diop advocated for sharing leadership beyond men to include the women of Southern Sudan so that they too could bring their agenda on peace and security to the table.

To exercise this type of leadership, one also needs to change the mindset of those who are used to being led in a particular way. For example, many leaders will complain about how people are hesitant to take the initiative or step up to the plate and influence others unless they have a title or the authority to do so. I find this is because many people have been socialised not to step out of line and are thus afraid. The words I have heard being used are: "Who do you think you are?" or "How dare you!" People, therefore, need to be assured that taking the initiative is welcome, and they will be supported to make good judgment calls.

For others, it is not fear but rather an unwillingness to take responsibility. It is safer and easier to stay small and only take instructions from the boss. This is about a lackadaisical attitude, which is where leadership gets complicated. It will require curiosity to better understand the person's goals and dreams for themselves, clarifying your expectations about them, stepping up, and holding them accountable for the desired behaviour.

It's about lighting a fire under someone so they are engaged, excited, and hungry for more. However, you, as the leader, can't do that alone. At some level, they have to want it, and they have to understand that there are consequences to their attitudes and behaviours.

Participatory Decision-Making to Develop Shared Leadership

Leadership literature indicates four ways of making decisions as a leader.

Option 1: You make the decision on your own.

Option 2: You consult others and then make your decision.

Option 3: You pull a team together and jointly come to a consensus on the decision to take.

Option 4: You delegate the decision to another person or team to make and support the decision regardless of what they decide.

Everything other than Option 1 will grow shared leadership in an organisation and should be used as much as possible. But please, note that there will be moments where Option 1 is the appropriate decision-making approach to take. So, how do you know which one to use and when?

Option One is ideal when the decision is well within your authority to make, time is constrained, others do not have the capacity or information to make an informed decision, you are clear on what needs to be done, and the decision will probably not be contested.

When you feel you need further information or are unsure about what decision to make, you can use **Option Two**, where you consult others.

When you need other people's buy-in for implementation, and the impact would be major on them, use **Option Three**.

If vested interests prevent the team from making an objective decision, you can use a combination of **Option Two** and **Three**, where the team comes up with options for you to decide.

Option Four is where the decision is appropriate when you are building the capacity of someone, and you believe they have the capacity to make a good decision.

Some leaders I have worked with have dismissed this more participatory and democratic way of making decisions and reflected in Options Two to Four as being too western and inappropriate for the African context. I always refute this and remind them of the many instances of participatory decision-making woven into the daily lives of Africans. Decisions around how to celebrate marriage and mourn the dead are made collectively by families. Decisions in religious institutions, voluntary organisations, and other associations are made collectively by a range of committees. I have observed that the communal spirit that cuts across the diverse African cultures legitimises and fosters participatory decision-making.

The other reason I have heard for not going with Option One is urgency. While I fully agree, one has to be careful, particularly if you are representing a group and speaking on their behalf as opposed to the hierarchical head of an organisation. Beatrice Grillo learned this the hard way. Beatrice is one of Zambia's most experienced women's rights leaders and an economist and Chartered Accountant who has worked in the parastatal and private sectors and served on many Boards, including the Zambia Governance Foundation.

At one point, Beatrice served as the Chair of the Non-Governmental Organisations Coordinating Council (NGOCC). One day, Beatrice issued a strong public statement in response to a national issue. Believing the matter to be urgent, Beatrice and her executive board did not consult the 107 member organisations of NGOCC before issuing the statement. While there was widespread public applause for her statement, some members were furious that their organisations were not consulted because of the perception it created of their organisations and, in some cases, their staff.

So, if the issue can affect some of the people you are leading, there is value in using Option Two and consulting before you decide, even when it appears urgent.

So, pause and reflect:

- How can you make your decisions more participatory?
- What would you need to do differently?

Let Others Take the Lead

At the beginning of this chapter, I recounted how I allowed a young man on his bicycle to lead me to the venue. At that moment, I appreciated that the young man had the expertise I didn't have; I trusted him to lead the way. This is because leadership isn't about always being in front. Sometimes, leaders have to follow those they lead.

This does not mean giving up your authority and responsibilities as a leader. Instead, it's about allowing others to influence the direction and actions your organisation may take. For example, if your organisation is facing a specific challenge, you may form a small team and charge them with finding solutions to the problem. You may also delegate a task to a direct report and only come in if there are problems or issues.

I facilitated the senior management team meetings of a corporate client for many years, and I noticed how the different Heads of Departments would show up. Some would come and do the presentations all by themselves. Others would allow various team members to lead in the presentation, answer questions on behalf of the team, and would only step in when someone needed support. In this way, you could see how these Heads of Departments were grooming their direct reports for leadership and to succeed in them. They were not giving up their responsibilities as leaders; instead, they created opportunities for others to step up and shine.

So, pause and reflect:

- What do I need to do to enable people to take the lead?
- How can I create an environment where people are willing to take the initiative?

Build Powerful Teams

Marcos Bitew is a successful entrepreneur and the CEO and Founder of the African Power Initiative. One of the things he ascribes his success to is the ability to put together highly effective teams. He never runs a “sole proprietorship.”

Marcos always looks out for maturity and the ability to think. He has the eye to carefully select people who are well trained in the particular field needed; he will then take a back seat and allow them to run things. This unique skill of Marcos comes from his understanding of his specialities, his limitations, and when to let go so others can manage projects he has started.

Teams are a powerful way to develop shared leadership in an organisation. When people work in a team, they learn how to share power and influence others to achieve a shared goal. There are three ways an organisation can leverage the power of teams to build shared leadership.

1. **Start at the top.** Ensure the leadership team is a real team. Most leadership teams are groups and are only teams in the name. This is because they are primarily interested in achieving results within their function or department and do not have any results for which they are jointly responsible. In other words, beyond the organisation’s mission, they don’t have a joint purpose for which they are collectively responsible. In addition, members of the leadership team work in isolation from one another. Staff take the cue from their leaders and also work in silos. Staff or departments that need information from others suffer because collaborating and helping others are not prioritised.

I have also seen leadership teams where members disassociate themselves from the decisions made as a group. This often happens when the manager believes that the decision taken by the bigger Management Team is unpopular with their team.

Finally, there are leadership teams in which people are afraid to say what they truly think because they are afraid of conflict or because dissent is not encouraged. All these are symptoms of a leadership team in name only. It is also a huge missed opportunity to develop shared leadership. If you are the CEO or a member of the senior leadership team, evolving from the group to a real team will require addressing any of the issues I have just described.

2. **Encourage more teamwork within the organisation.** Rather than always working in isolation, encourage staff to achieve joint results, collaborate, share information, and support each other. This should happen within and across functions or departments. Ultimately, whether you are two people in the organisation or one hundred, shared leadership blossoms in a culture of teamwork.
3. **Periodically put together cross-functional teams to address specific challenges or achieve a specific result on behalf of the organisation.** These teams have a limited life and are in place for a specific reason. In these instances, research has shown that the team’s success is largely a factor of its design.[21] It is about ensuring there is clarity of purpose for the team and then getting the right people in terms of diversity of skills and mix of personalities shared onto the team.

The twenty-first-century workplace is increasingly characterised by less hierarchical structures as virtual teams and market expansion become vehicles for competitive advantage. People are moving around as

they build their careers. It is no longer prudent for organisations to limit their leadership to one or two competent and indispensable individuals. COVID-19 forced many organisations to work remotely to curtail the spread of the virus.

For many battling to keep their business afloat without downsizing human resources, they are opted to sell their buildings or give up their leases and offer teams the option to work from home or wherever is convenient. Virtual communication and meeting platforms have also shifted the hierarchy because we now see seniors in their homes as people. This may have been less likely in physical office structures where seniors sit on the top floor, have private entrances, and are only seen during roadshows and special presentations.

Shared leadership is something we need to cultivate as team members organise themselves to get things done. Admittedly, not all individuals and leaders are ready for this, as it is almost counterintuitive to historical leadership practices on the continent. Schools and religious organisations have perpetuated it. Mainstream schools offer one curriculum devised by a select few, a limited way of teaching it, a Memorandum of correct answers, and success equates to recall of said curriculum. A decade or more does not prepare us fully for university and much less for a culture of accountability and broad-based teamwork and competence needed to solve problems critically. We are trained to sit down and wait for information, instruction, and feedback. But the cost of not starting outweighs the comfort zone.

But we know that shared leadership is important. According to the Harvard Business Review, shared leadership improves organisational performance. When individuals feel that they have an impact on the organisation and that they have some power and responsibility, they have a greater desire for success.[22] Goals become more personal when we feel we have a say and people are relying on us. Naturally, we work harder at anything we are personally and emotionally invested in.

So, pause and reflect:

- How can I create a culture of shared leadership in my organisation?
- What should we continue doing?
- What do we need to do differently?

In a bid to proactively analyse and solve the challenges across our continent, we should work toward the ultimate goal of leadership: leading in ways that create more leaders. Our support and example should inspire others to gear toward a shared vision, a noble ideal greater than ourselves. The first two parts of this book have prepared us to look critically yet lovingly within ourselves, placing us firmly on the path to expanding our strengths and addressing our weaknesses to get to the point of interpersonal leadership and achieving results through others.

The world will continue to evolve and through this, our need for agility increases. It is a great journey borne out of the desire to leave the world just a little better by living our purpose.

[20] Asingwire, Peterson and Byamugisha, Joan. "A Runyakitara Culture Wiki." *Journal of Language, Technology & Entrepreneurship in Africa*. Vol. 5 No. 2 (2014).

[21] Edmondson, Amy. *Teaming: How Organisations Learn, Innovate, and Compete in the Knowledge Economy*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, Inc., 2012.

[22] <https://hbr.org/2016/05/how-shared-leadership-changes-our-relationships-at-work>

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